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YES, IT CAN BE DONE

We need a national commitment and strong leadership if we are serious about our desire to deliver on world-class infrastructure and create a force multiplier

Even after 60 years of Independence, it is deplorable that we are yet to put our infrastructure in place. There are two types of infrastructure in the country. One is basic infrastructure, such as water supply, drainage, education and health cover, which caters to some basic necessities. The other is for comfort that a paved economy delivers—excellent roads, high-speed trains, etc. You could say we have not delivered on either. What is the problem? Is it lack of money, lack of funds? I do not think so, although this is something everybody talks about. Money is not the problem; we simply don't know how to go about getting things done.

Let me give you two of my favourite examples. Take housing—mass affordable housing. What have we achieved? In Delhi we have created a mammoth body like the Delhi Development Authority (DDA). What has it done? The DDA is sitting on a pile of investments; it is sitting on funds and was offering to lend the Delhi Metro money. Is it for want of funds that it failed to perform? They don't know what to do with the money. Take water. Again, let us look at Delhi. We are sitting on the banks of the Yamuna here. The Ganges is hardly 150 km away. Is it so difficult to visualise the solution? What is lacking is we don't know how to go about it. What we have done is that we have created many layers of decision-making and too many agencies and regulators. Most of the regulatory jobs are simply a cushy job for retired bureaucrats. In this country we have to get too many clearances to get anything done.

I think we need to re-engineer the entire process. It is not difficult. We have done it in Delhi Metro and ear-

lier in the Konkan Railway. We need to get our objectives and the systems aligned. What is happening now is that the government takes a decision to do something and then the matter goes through the process of clearances. Every department—because of ego, and mostly because of ego—decides to question the entire project. A decision of the government almost derailed. Why should this be so? People often talk about how things get done in China. Does this happen in China? Do their own departments question the decision of the government? We have ideas but we don't know how to deliver, how to execute the ideas into reality.

We must get out of this rut. I will suggest a multi-pronged approach but before anything else I must stress on one vital ingredient. We need leadership, not just in politics but also in administration. Look at the fate of the national highways project and how so many chairmen have been transferred. Is this any way to go about things? When I was in Konkan Railway, I had issues with ministers who wanted to change me. They wrote to the prime minister. The prime minister summoned and told me: "Sreedharan, you are doing a good job and please go ahead. We have no intention to shift you." Why can't these sort of messages go to heads of these organisations? Delhi Metro succeeded because I have been here for the last 11 years. You can't change the guard only because a politician thinks so. How do the Ambanis and Tatas accomplish their tasks? In the same country, the private sector is able to achieve whatever it wants.

Nobody considers the cost of delay. In Delhi Metro, the main driving force for us was the realisation that each day that a project was delayed would

PRESCRIPTION

➤ The objectives and the systems need to be aligned to turn ideas into reality

➤ Define the objective—why, what, where, when—and be clear on the ideology—who will do what

➤ Identify the right person for a job and then trust and support him throughout